

Every Algebraic Number is a Critical Value of an Integer Polynomial

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Abstract

For every nonconstant $f \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ we construct $g \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ and an irreducible $H \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ with $H \mid g'$ and $H^2 \mid f \circ g$. Equivalently, every algebraic number is a critical value of an integer polynomial, so the set of critical values of $\mathbb{Z}[x]$ is exactly $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$. The construction is explicit. The proof was assisted by AI, and has been formalized in Lean.

1 Introduction

A critical value of a nonconstant $g \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ is a number α with $g(\beta) = \alpha$ and $g'(\beta) = 0$ for some β . Since $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$ is closed under polynomial evaluation, every critical value is algebraic. This note proves the converse, and does so with an explicit construction.

Theorem 1. *Let $f \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ be nonconstant. Then there exist $g, H \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ with H irreducible in $\mathbb{Z}[x]$ and $1 \leq \deg H$, such that*

$$H \mid g' \quad \text{and} \quad H^2 \mid f \circ g \quad \text{in } \mathbb{Z}[x].$$

The g produced satisfies $\deg g \geq 2$.

The corollary is the statement in the title.

Corollary 1. *The set of critical values is exactly $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}$.*

2 The construction

Let $h \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ be a primitive irreducible factor of f , of degree n , with root θ . If $h = x$, then $g = x^2$ and $H = x$ work. Otherwise $h(0) \neq 0$, and since $\gcd(h, h') = 1$ in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$, the elimination ideal $(h, h') \cap \mathbb{Z}$ is a nonzero ideal of $\mathbb{Z}$; let ρ generate it,

$$|\rho| = \min\{|c| : c \in (h, h') \cap \mathbb{Z}, c \neq 0\}, \quad u h + v h' = \rho \quad (u, v \in \mathbb{Z}[x]),$$

which the extended Euclidean algorithm in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ produces on clearing denominators, and set

$$M = \rho h(0), \quad H(x) = \frac{h(Mx)}{h(0)}, \quad W(x) = \frac{v(0)H(x) - v(Mx)}{\rho}.$$

The polynomial claimed by Theorem 1 is

$$g(x) = Mx + h(Mx)W(x)$$

together with this H .

Theorem (restatement of Theorem 1). *H is irreducible in $\mathbb{Z}[x]$, and $H \mid g'$ and $H^2 \mid f \circ g$ in $\mathbb{Z}[x]$.*

Verification. Let $\beta = \theta/M$, a root of H . Since $H(0) = 1$, the constant terms in W cancel, and every other coefficient carries M^j with $\rho h(0) \mid M$, so $W \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$ and $W(0) = 0$; likewise $H, g \in \mathbb{Z}[x]$. Then $W(\beta) = -v(\theta)/\rho = -1/h'(\theta)$, so

$$g(\beta) = \theta, \quad g'(\beta) = M(1 + h'(\theta)W(\beta)) = 0.$$

Hence β is a double root of $f \circ g$, and H is primitive irreducible, so $H \mid g'$ and $H^2 \mid f(g)$ in $\mathbb{Z}[x]$ by Gauss.

The computation uses $h(\theta) = 0$ and nothing else about θ , so it runs at every root of h at once: all n conjugates are critical values of the same g , at the n points θ_i/M . That is what makes H^2 , and not merely $(x - \beta)^2$, divide $f \circ g$.

Only the relation $uh + vh' = \rho$ is used, so any nonzero element of $(h, h') \cap \mathbb{Z}$ serves $-\text{Res}(h, h')$ among them, which is a multiple of ρ . The generator is taken because $M = \rho h(0)$ multiplies into every coefficient of H, W and g , so the smallest ρ gives the smallest answer. On $h = x^2 + 1$ the resultant is 4 against $\rho = 2$, and on Dedekind's cubic below it is 2012 against 1006.

3 Examples

Each line below is a closed identity, checkable by expansion.

Example 1 ($f = qx - p, p \neq 0, \gcd(p, q) = 1$). Here $h' = q$ and $p = qx - h$, so $(h, h') \cap \mathbb{Z} = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\rho = 1$. Choose $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $ap + bq = 1$ and take $u = -a, v = ax + b$; then $h_0 = -p, M = -p, H = qx + 1, W = x$, and

$$g = -pqx^2 - 2px, \quad g' = -2p(qx + 1), \quad f \circ g = -p(qx + 1)^2.$$

Note $\deg v = n$: the minimal ρ is not in general attainable with $\deg v < n$, which for this h would force $q \mid \rho$.

Example 2 ($f = x^2 + 1$). With $u = 2, v = -x, \rho = 2, h_0 = 1, M = 2, H = 4x^2 + 1$ and $W = x$,

$$g = 4x^3 + 3x, \quad g' = 3(4x^2 + 1), \quad f \circ g = (4x^2 + 1)^2(x^2 + 1).$$

Here $\deg g = 3 = n + 1$, the least degree any solution can have. The unit group $\mathcal{O}_K^\times = \{\pm 1, \pm i\}$ has rank 0, and it is $\mathbb{Z}[i/2] = \mathbb{Z}[i][1/2]$ that supplies the needed unit $1 + i$.

Example 3 ($f = x^3 - 2$). With $u = 3, v = -x, \rho = -6, h_0 = -2, M = 12, H = 1 - 864x^3$ and $W = -2x$,

$$g = -3456x^4 + 16x, \quad g' = 16(1 - 864x^3).$$

Example 4 ($f = x^3 - x - 1$). The construction gives $M = 23$ and a sextic. A hand-tuned quintic also witnesses the *statement*, and is a useful independent check of it:

$$g = -24334x^5 + 39675x^4 - 26450x^3 + 9085x^2 - 1610x + 118, \quad H = 23x^3 - 23x^2 + 8x - 1,$$

with $g' = -230(23x - 7)H$ and $H^2 \mid f \circ g$, the cofactor having degree 9.

Example 5 (Dedekind's cubic). $f = x^3 - x^2 - 2x - 8$, the standard example of a field whose ring of integers is not monogenic: 2 is a common index divisor [Ded78]. With $u = 21x - 125, v = -7x^2 + 44x - 3, \rho = 1006, h_0 = -8, M = -8048$,

$$H = 65158925824x^3 + 8096288x^2 - 2012x + 1, \quad W = -194310912x^3 + 426544x^2 + 358x,$$

$$g = 101288722414414331904x^6 - 209759614012620800x^5 \\ - 217370176548864x^4 - 14767629312x^3 + 2350016x^2 - 10912x.$$

4 Formalization

The development above has been formalized in Lean 4 [MU21] against Mathlib [The20], in about 1,200 lines. The main statement is

```
1 theorem main (f : Z[X]) (hf : 1 <= f.natDegree) :
2   exists g H : Z[X], Irreducible H /\ H \mid derivative g /\ H^2 \mid f.comp g
```

with a strengthened form carrying $2 \leq \deg g$ and $1 \leq \deg H$, and with Corollary 1 proved from it. Every result depends only on the three standard axioms `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`.

References

- [Ded78] Richard Dedekind. “Über den Zusammenhang zwischen der Theorie der Ideale und der Theorie der höheren Kongruenzen”. In: *Abhandlungen der Königlichen Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen* (1878).
- [The20] The mathlib Community. “The Lean Mathematical Library”. In: *Certified Programs and Proofs (CPP 2020)*. ACM, 2020.
- [MU21] Leonardo de Moura and Sebastian Ullrich. “The Lean 4 Theorem Prover and Programming Language”. In: *Automated Deduction – CADE 28*. Lecture Notes in Computer Science. Springer, 2021.